UNDER SIEGE

ASADUDDIN OWAISI AND HIS AIMIM ARE FEELING THE PRESSURE IN THEIR HYDERABAD BASTION

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FIGHT MODE AIMIM leader Asaduddin Owaisi after filing his LS nomination papers, Hyderabad, Apr. 19

Beginning in the 1950s, and especially over the past four decades, the Owaisis and their All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) have run an unchallenged political monopoly in Hyderabad. While not losing the Lok Sabha constituency even once since 1984, the party has also done well in the assembly. Even in the November-December 2023 state polls, it won seven seats, largely in the Muslim quarters of the Old City. One of these, Nampally, in fact, falls outside the LS constituency. But this thumbnail sketch, implying total area domination, also conceals a few truths.

The key nuance is that since 2014, the AIMIM vote share in its traditional stronghold has come down in the Telangana assembly election. In fact, in the latest iteration, the party came close to losing two of its sure seats—Nampally and Yakutpura—scraping through in the latter by 878 votes. This is not counting the Goshamahal assembly seat in Hyderabad, which the party has always lost. This is where the controversial Muslim-baiter, T. Raja Singh of the BJP, who has 105 criminal cases against him, has won thrice since 2014.

So, is the AIMIM losing ground? Opinion is divided among Muslims, and that at a time when firebrand party chief Asaduddin Owaisi has dreams of taking the party national. The countervailing fact? While the AIMIM vote share in the assembly is down, the AIMIM supremo has won the Hyderabad LS seat by polling more than 50 per cent of the votes in 2014 and 2019. Both times, his main rival was the influential Bhagavanth Rao of the BJP.

This time, the saffron side has fielded a woman, hospital owner Kompella Madhavi Latha. She hit the trail early, even before she had formally joined the party and the election schedule was announced in March, and is looking to consolidate the 230,000-odd catchment votes Rao would get and perhaps try for another 100,000 sympathisers to tilt the scales. Latha has already upped the ante. "I am here to fulfil PM Modi's mission...he has sent me here to cut someone's *patang* (kite)," she declared early on. The kite is the poll symbol of the AIMIM. Educationist Gaddam Srinivas Yadav (BRS) and district Congress president Sameer Waliullah are the other candidates in the fight.

THE AIMIM BARELY SCRAPED THROUGH IN TWO OF ITS SURE SEATS IN THE 2023 TELANGANA ASSEMBLY POLL

However, on April 17, during a Ram Navami procession in the Old City, Latha found herself in a spot when a video of her shooting off an imaginary arrow at the Siddiamber Bazar mosque went viral. Stung by the outcry, Latha was forced to issue an apology on social media platform X. Owaisi, though, was determined to squeeze every ounce of advantage out of the outrage, wondering aloud why the Election Commission was turning a blind eye. "The people of Hyderabad have seen the BJP's intentions.... Is this the 'Viksit Bharat' the BJP is talking about?" he asked. "Elections have their own place. What is more important is the peace of Telangana and Hyderabad...the brotherhood, fraternity prevailing here, which they (the BJP) want to destroy." On a complaint, the Hyderabad police booked a case of deliberate and malicious intent to "outrage religious feelings" against Latha.

Still, analysts point to various factors behind the AIMIM being under pressure this time. For one, the party and the earlier Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) government were quite supportive of each other. But the BRS's electoral